

Google News

The conventional way to read the top stories of the day is to pick-up your favourite newspaper—or more appropriately in this online age—is to visit your favourite news Web site. There is, however, a drawback with this approach: the news you read is limited to a single publisher's perspective.

Google News (news.google.com) attempts to be different. Rather than be limited to the views of a single publisher, Google News works on the principle that there is more than one news source for the same story. Thus, stories are grouped together around one news event than around any one particular news provider. The cool part is, the process is automated. Google's computers scan over 4,500 English-language news sources to collate stories of the past 30 days and to display them according to the user's personalisation.

With its usual gusto for content engineering, Google's computers evaluate and rank the stories based on their heady brew of clustering algorithms (<http://tinyurl.com/yh8697>) using multiple parameters to judge a story's newsworthiness. This supposedly provides one with an unbiased, non-political, non-ideologically-driven news engine that is customisable to reflect your personal interests. While detractors will say that a mix of news sources, collectively without a point of view, is like a bland dish, we like to think that Google News provides all the ingredients to whip up our own personalised dish of spicy news served steaming hot over data pipes!

But before we delve in for a deeper look at its features there may be some of you who are wondering if it is only an "English Affair." Well, there is good news and bad news. The good news is that Google News is available in a large number of international languages and regional editions. India is one of the regional editions, but with a caveat (this is the bad news): as of now, it's only